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What Makes a Postal Address "Ready"?

Preparing for the Postal Address Mandate starts with understanding what "ready" actually means.



Contact

Prepare for November
2026



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These are important questions. But they all assume one thing. That the organization already knows what a **ready** postal address looks like. In practice, that definition is often missing. Without it, remediation programs risk becoming large-scale transformation projects without a clear objective.

Address readiness is not about creating perfect customer records. It is about understanding whether existing customer address data can be represented in accordance with the applicable Postal Address Mandate requirements, identifying where remediation is required and establishing a sustainable approach to maintaining address quality.

The Postal Address Mandate is changing address representation, not customer addresses

One common misconception is that the Postal Address Mandate requires financial institutions to collect different customer address information.

Most institutions already hold much of the information they need. The challenge is determining whether existing customer address data can support the required representation in ISO 20022 payment messages and identifying where information is incomplete, inconsistent, or missing.

Customer address data has often been collected over many years through different onboarding channels, customer master systems, core banking platforms and acquisitions. Some systems store address components separately. Others rely on free-text fields. Different business units and jurisdictions follow different conventions for formatting and maintaining addresses.



Payment systems consume address data. They do not create it.

When organisations begin preparing for the Postal Address Mandate, attention naturally turns to payment infrastructure. That is understandable. Payment messages are where the new requirements become visible. They are rarely where the challenge begins.

Every customer address included in a payment message has already passed through onboarding, customer master systems, KYC processes and operational workflows before reaching the payment engine.

If address information is incomplete, inconsistent or stored differently across those systems, the payment message simply reflects those conditions. This is why many Postal Address Mandate programmes quickly extend beyond payment operations and involve customer data, onboarding, compliance and governance teams.

Four questions every institution should ask about address readiness

Rather than asking whether address data is simply "good", organizations should ask whether it is ready for the Postal Address Mandate. That starts with four practical questions.

Can we represent it?

Can existing customer address data be represented in the format required for the applicable payment scenario?



The objective is not to make every historical record identical. It is to consistently produce compliant payment messages.

Can we trust it?

Is the same customer represented consistently across systems? Conflicting address records increase transformation complexity, create unnecessary exceptions, and reduce confidence in downstream processes.

Do we have sufficient information?

Not every historical customer record contains every address component. The important question is whether sufficient information exists to produce a compliant payment message or whether remediation, enrichment, or customer outreach is required.

Can we maintain it?

Historical remediation addresses existing data. Address readiness also depends on the quality of new data entering the organisation. Without appropriate governance, today's remediation program becomes tomorrow's data quality problem.

Address readiness is not a one-time exercise

One of the most important planning considerations is recognizing that the Postal Address Mandate creates two distinct challenges.





Address readiness therefore requires two complementary capabilities: one that addresses historical data at scale and another that supports ongoing address representation as new data enters payment flows.

Looking beyond compliance

The November 2026 deadline is an important milestone. It should not become the finish line.

Financial institutions that use the Postal Address Mandate to strengthen customer data management are likely to realize benefits beyond compliance. Better address quality can contribute to improved straight-through processing, fewer payment exceptions, more effective sanctions screening, and a stronger foundation for future ISO 20022 initiatives.

Every institution will define address readiness differently. Some will focus on achieving compliance through hybrid address representation where appropriate. Others will use the program to accelerate broader customer data modernization and progressively adopt fully structured addresses.

Both approaches can be valid. What matters is defining the target before remediation begins.

That decision influences technology choices, remediation priorities, governance models and, ultimately, the long-term value of the program.

Catalyst Data Intelligence supports this journey by helping financial institutions assess customer address data, identify remediation priorities, and transform address information into representations aligned with the applicable Postal Address Mandate requirements.



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